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Point to prove: Shreyas Iyer and Ishan Kishan were overlooked for BCCI's 2023-24 retainers list, with the board at the time stressing the importance of participating in domestic cricket when not playing for the national team. **R. V. MOORTHY**

months — two against Bangladesh and three against New Zealand at home, and five against Australia in its backyard.

The participation of as many as 19 capped Test players, even if only for the first round, to sharpen their skills ahead of the crucial phase, underscores that domestic cricket

from the Duleep Trophy in Anantapur and Bengaluru, which has dropped the zonal format this year. The national selection panel, led by Ajit Agarkar, has selected four teams — India A, India B, India C, and India D — each comprising 15 players.

Plenty at stake

Seldom in the recent past has a domestic tournament thrown up as many storylines as this Duleep Trophy. The most prominent is the new lease of life offered to Ishan and Shreyas.

Shreyas was given a chance during India's white-ball series against Sri Lanka in July, while Kishan began his comeback in the Buchi Babu Invitational tournament. A series of strong performances here and in the Ranji Trophy could propel both players back into the Test side. Kishan hasn't featured in any form of international cricket since opting out of the two-Test series in South Africa, while Iyer, left out after the second Test against England, missed the Ranji Trophy quarterfinals due to back spasms, despite being medically cleared by the board's doctors.

Then there is Rishabh Pant. His flamboyance had proved crucial in India edging past Australia the last time it went Down Under for a Test series. Coming off a year-long injury hiatus after a road accident, Pant has been able to get back in the limited-overs side. While his reputation alone warrants a place in the Test team, especially for the Australia series, having to go through the rigours of domestic cricket will only ease his re-entry into the side.

Contesting Pant for the same spot is K.L. Rahul, who is trying to replenish his stocks in the longer format. A hundred in South Africa as wicketkeeper-batter in December

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This September, several Indian cricket A-listers will join forces to reignite the Duleep Trophy, aiming to restore its relevance. The tournament will serve as a dress rehearsal for the packed Test calendar that lies ahead for Rohit Sharma and his team.

India has played only seven Test matches in the past 13 months, with the most recent one against England in March. Now, the team is set to play 10 Tests over the next four

has indeed risen on the selectors' priority list. It also indicates that the omissions of Ishan Kishan and Shreyas Iyer from the central contracts list earlier this year for not playing for their Ranji Trophy teams was not merely posturing.

The only major absentees will be Virat Kohli, who last played a Test match in January, along with Rohit, Jasprit Bumrah, and R. Ashwin — the four guaranteed starters whom the selectors are keen to wrap in cotton wool for the Border-Gavaskar Trophy later this year. Mohammad Shami, recovering from ankle surgery, won't be fit in time for the tournament but is expected to return for Bengal in the Ranji Trophy in October.

Even with this quintet missing, the spotlight is unlikely to shift away